COUNSELING TRAINEE/OBSERVER AGREEMENT

Welcome to GraceLife Counseling, the Counseling Ministry of GraceLife Church

GraceLife Counseling looks forward to your participation as a biblical counseling trainee. We hope that what you observe will serve you well as you pursue service to the Lord through your training. We are thankful for you and seek to serve you as you pursue your call to ministry for God's glory. Please take the time to read and sign this important document that explains what you should know, expect and agree to as a trainee.

What You Can Expect from Us and Why You Need to Be Involved

What Is Biblical Counseling?

Biblical counseling can be condensed into these four basic commitments: the rendering of gracious care and hope, the acquiring of personal information with a biblical interpretation, biblical truth, and specific application. It is intensely practical and relies heavily on the comprehensive gathering of information for understanding (Proverbs 25:11, 13).

Biblical counseling is counsel based on God's Word as the ultimate source of truth and restoration for the believer in Christ. For the GraceLife Counseling counselor, there is an operative conviction that God's Word is relevant to all of life and can be practically applied to every heart and every circumstance of difficulty. While this does not imply that Scripture is the only source of information in the counseling process, biblical counselors are consistent in their detailed biblical analysis of information and their overwhelming focus on the Bible, which alone is infallible, authoritative and sufficient truth for matters of eternal life and godliness (2 Timothy 3:16; Hebrews 4:12; 2 Peter 1:3ff). Every counseling system consists of certain elements. Biblical counseling is a complete system that is consistent with biblical theology.

Biblical counseling does not set aside real-life issues, but works to understand their origin, impact and involvement in the counselee's life from a biblical perspective. It acknowledges that the counselee possesses both physical and spiritual components that interact and affect one another because he or she is a whole spiritual person (2 Corinthians 4:16-18). It seeks to hear and understand the counselee and apply the truth of Scripture (gospel truths, who God is, and all the biblical elements of change) to the counselee's life, so that through Jesus Christ there can be restoration where there is brokenness (Revelation 21:5). The biblical counselor will also often refer the counselee to get a medical check-up to see if there are physical complications involved in the issue at hand.

The biblical counselor strives to relate the counselees not to themselves to bring about healing, but to Jesus Christ and His Word that sets men free (Hebrews 4:14-16; John 8:32). In doing so, biblical counseling is dependent on the collaborative, supernatural resources that God has provided for change (the work of the Holy Spirit, the Word of God, the grace of Jesus Christ through the gospel, and the involvement of the local church). As the counselees contemplate and apply who God is and His Word to their hearts and lives, they are over time transformed further into God's own image by the Holy Spirit's power (2 Corinthians 3:18; Philippians 2:12).

While behavioral change is important to this process of transformation, change within the counselee's heart (affections, thoughts, intentions) is essential as the counselor guides the

counselee to a right understanding of God, the counselee's situation, and how Christians change. Through cultivating the counselee's faith, gospel motivation, and desire for God's glory with prayerful diligent work, real change from the inside out is possible.

This redemptive transformation that takes place as the counselee's heart interacts with the Word of God brings hope, encouragement, conviction, repentance, and/or healing. As individuals find Christ sufficient, put to death the things of the flesh, and strengthen the things of the Spirit, joy and peace become realities in their Christian walk (Ephesians 4:24; Colossians 3:10). The biblical counselor is humbly privileged to see God work and assist in this process of spiritual growth and freedom toward God's glory.

Biblical Counseling and Psychotropic Medication

While we hold to the sufficiency of Scripture for counseling problems, we know that many who will come to us will have been prescribed medications by a physician. The biblical teaching on the importance of the body affirms the use of medication for physical problems. As biblical counselors, we do not offer medical advice including advice on withdrawing from medications. Our care for counselees may lead us to ask questions about the side-effects of medication, or whether the counselees have allowed the medication to take the place of the Lord as a refuge in their life. We will always encourage counselees with questions regarding medications, or who wish to discontinue using medications, to seek the advice of competent medical professionals before changing or discontinuing any medication.

What We Expect from You

What Is Your Role in Counseling?

We are so thankful for your desire to care for God's people through learning to provide loving counsel from His Word to those who are hurting. In attending counseling as a trainee, the requirements are fairly basic. We first ask for your commitment to see the counseling case through to its completion (only missing sessions in extreme situations). We ask that you would be **courteous**, **inconspicuous,** and **prompt** so that the counselor and counselee are able to proceed without any distractions. **Please only participate if the counselor asks you to do so.**

In sessions you will be privy to very personal information, often regarding sin in the counselee's life, as well as deeply painful events from his or her past. As part of honoring God and loving the counselee well, it is incredibly important that all information shared with you in counseling remains confidential. Should an issue concerning safety arise, the GraceLife Counseling counselor will address potential recourse based on the confidentiality limitations that will follow in this document.

As a trainee, you will be expected to exhibit Christ-like character in your communication throughout and following the counseling process in regard to any information you hear during sessions–letting no communication that is unwholesome/destructive come from your mouth, but only that which is good for building up (Ephesians 4:29-31).

Should you ever be unable to attend a counseling session, it will fall to the counselor to decide whether to proceed with the session without you. Though we appreciate your participation and are eager to help in your training, the counselor will most likely not be able to adjust scheduling to the trainee as he/she will be striving instead to plan around the counselee and the advocate's time.

The aforementioned expectations of your participation are consistent for all counseling at GraceLife Counseling. **Please also note, your ten hours of counseling observation must be with an approved ACBC certified counselor.**

Materials Needed for Counseling Sessions

1. Bible, notebook, pen/pencil
   a. You are encouraged to take as many notes as you like, but do this quietly and effortlessly. A noisy pencil or shaking the counseling table with writing can be very distracting. The purpose of notes is to better help the counselor and the counselee.

   b. Pertinent details of the first couple of sessions while gathering the counselee's history should be taken down, as well as questions you may have for the counselor as you listen.

2. Any assigned homework (if you also were asked to participate) and Counseling Observation

   Form
   a. After each session, you are to fill out a "Counseling Observation Form." Each trainee reports on each session he or she observes. The Observation forms should be handled with great care and given only to the counselor.

   b. The purpose of these reports is to benefit the trainee in processing the session and how to become a biblical counselor.

3. A humble, loving spirit that seeks your brother's or sister's good

   a. You are expected to pray for the counselor leading the session and for the counselee receiving help.

   b. You are also encouraged to keep the counselor and counselee in prayer in between sessions. We rely on God's Word and the Holy Spirit for guidance and help. This requires us to be a praying people.

I have read and agree to abide by the above information.

Observer Name (print): _____

Observer Signature:_____Date_____